superiors at first sight. Initially, despite my best efforts, things did not go as well as I would have wanted. I had a tough time making the general agree with my views and recommendations in quite a few cases. Not to be deterred, I endeavoured to learn my job as fast as possible.

Returning from a tour one fine day, he called for me and said, 'JJ, I didn't know that you were such a good combat leader, and that you had commanded your brigade so well in Kashmir. Your men are very proud of you even today.' I wondered as to who had spoken to him about me. Subsequently, I learnt that during a recent tour he had got talking to a junior commissioned officer (JCO) from a Rajputana Rifles battalion who had been detailed as his liaison officer in Jodhpur. That battalion had served under me in Kashmir during 1991–92. The JCO must have recounted some operational experience where I had figured prominently. All I can say is that the rest of my tenure with General Samay Ram passed smoothly. A good spoken reputation does matter for us soldiers, particularly if the praise comes from someone who has served under one's command during operations.

During this tenure there were some important assignments or events that took place. I was called by the master general of ordnance (MGO), Lieutenant General R.I.S. Kahlon, in early 1995 and told to carry out a study that would review the requirements and scale of transport in units of the Indian Army, prior to the introduction of the new family of vehicles. Over the next five years the new generation 2.5-ton 'Azad Super' and 5/7.5-ton 'Stallion' vehicles would replace the existing 1-ton and 3-ton vehicles that were based on the obsolete technology of the 1960s. The MGO gave me only three months to complete this study whose implications would have an impact for decades – an almost unachievable task.

The only way I could do so was to cut out the red tape and long-winded bureaucratic procedures, and go down to the grassroots level of units and sub units directly. This innovative approach involved the creation of a study group comprising officers of the rank of colonels of all arms and services of the army. The next step was to form sub-teams to look into specific areas. After initial